

# Sapiens — Mastery Quiz

Author: Yuval Noah Harari • 12 multiple-choice questions • Answer + explanation

Instructions: Choose the best answer before checking the answer and explanation.

## 1. *What helped Homo sapiens cooperate on a massive scale?*

- A. Physical strength alone
- B. Shared stories and imagined orders
- C. Isolation
- D. No language

**Correct answer: B**

**Why:** Shared beliefs allow large groups of strangers to coordinate.

## 2. *What are the three major revolutions highlighted?*

- A. Industrial, Digital, Space
- B. Cognitive, Agricultural, Scientific
- C. Bronze, Iron, Nuclear
- D. Language, Money, Internet

**Correct answer: B**

**Why:** These revolutions mark major transformations in human cognition, society and knowledge.

## 3. *Why is money powerful according to the book's framework?*

- A. It is biologically necessary
- B. It is a shared system of trust and belief
- C. It cannot change
- D. It eliminates cooperation

**Correct answer: B**

**Why:** Money works because large numbers of people trust the shared system.

## 4. *What was a major trade-off of agriculture?*

- A. No population growth
- B. More food and population alongside new labor and hierarchy
- C. Elimination of states
- D. Less specialization

**Correct answer: B**

**Why:** Agriculture enabled scale but also created new dependencies and inequalities.

**5. What is cumulative culture?**

- A. Each generation starts over
- B. Later generations build on previous knowledge
- C. Culture never changes
- D. Only genes transmit knowledge

**Correct answer: B**

**Why:** Cumulative learning gives humans an unusual ability to accelerate cultural change.

**6. What does a 'shared fiction' mean in the book?**

- A. A personal lie
- B. A collectively accepted abstract concept or institution
- C. A scientific law
- D. A physical object

**Correct answer: B**

**Why:** Nations, corporations and currencies depend on shared conceptual frameworks.

**7. Why are corporations an example of imagined order?**

- A. They are animals
- B. They are legal/social entities sustained by collective belief and rules
- C. They cannot coordinate people
- D. They existed before humans

**Correct answer: B**

**Why:** The corporate entity exists through legal and social institutions.

**8. What changed during the Scientific Revolution?**

- A. Systematic discovery became central
- B. Humans stopped experimenting
- C. Agriculture disappeared
- D. Language vanished

**Correct answer: A**

**Why:** Modern science emphasizes admitting ignorance and systematically acquiring new knowledge.

**9. What is one major effect of technology and culture together?**

- A. They can transform ecosystems and societies
- B. They prevent cooperation
- C. They eliminate institutions
- D. They stop population growth

**Correct answer: A**

**Why:** Cumulative culture and technology amplify human impact.

**10. What does the book suggest about progress?**

- A. Every change benefits everyone equally
- B. Changes can create both benefits and costs
- C. Progress never has costs
- D. History is purely biological

**Correct answer: B**

**Why:** Historical transformations often improve some dimensions while creating new problems.

**11. What enables millions of strangers to cooperate?**

- A. Personal friendship with everyone
- B. Shared rules, stories and institutions
- C. Identical DNA
- D. No specialization

**Correct answer: B**

**Why:** Institutions and shared narratives coordinate people beyond face-to-face groups.

**12. What is a useful question when studying society through *Sapiens*?**

- A. What shared story coordinates people?
- B. Who is the strongest individual?
- C. How can cooperation be eliminated?
- D. Why does culture not matter?

**Correct answer: A**

**Why:** The book repeatedly highlights shared narratives as a foundation of large-scale cooperation.

Scoring guide: 10–12 = strong mastery • 7–9 = good understanding • 4–6 = review the summary • 0–3  
= reread the core concepts.